



The 'Miracle Drug'

Cocaine was thought to be a wonder drug in its time, and it almost destroyed the lives of two medical revolutionaries. <http://dgit.in/XrHsIv>



What lies beneath

A gallery of deep-sea creatures, straight out of a twisted horror movie. <http://dgit.in/YcytbF>

One Drug to rule them all

Is a smart-drug better than a slap on the face?

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A rush of blood to the head, followed by a shifting of the senses to overdrive. The book you have been trying to read (or maybe even write) for weeks - over in a day. Stock Exchange numbers flow out of the screen and tell you things you could never hear before, and that classmate you have been unsuccessfully trying to woo? Your extraordinary intelligence has smashed all barriers between you two. Basically, there is nothing you can't do.

This was the premise of the sci-fi film *Limitless*, a movie which has to be watched with a handful of salt. Here our hero, a failed novelist lives in a crummy apartment and watches Bruce Lee movies while stuffing himself with chips. Unable to get any work done, he stumbles onto a drug, NZT, which allows him to think clearly and focus. Suddenly, every bit of information he has been exposed to throughout his whole life organizes itself and is ready for the taking. With NZT, he finishes writing his book, gets his girlfriend back, battles ruthless business giants, and eventually stands a possibility of being elected as the President. Things do get hairy in the middle, as they would in a thriller movie, but the premise remains; take this drug and get smarter, faster, and better.

Laughable? Yes. Impossible? Maybe not. The real life answer to NZT lies in what are called 'smart drugs' or nootropics.

The brain consists of billions of neurotransmitters and synapses which govern several elements of your mind such as grasping power, intellectual performance, and even your mood. Altering the different levels of various chemicals in the



Definitely a good idea to mess around with these. Right?

brain could result in better functioning in these specific areas. In addition, a lot of nootropics also increase the blood flow in the brain, thus increasing the delivery of oxygen throughout your system which enhance recall and focus.

Nootropics, roughly translated from Greek means 'to bend the mind'. Coined in 1972 by Romanian Doctor Corneliu E. Giurgea when he synthesised *Piracetam*, the first 'smart drug', the word now refers to a large variety of smart drugs which increase cognitive functioning and awareness. But this was the first synthesis of a nootropic in a lab. Since thousands of years, the Chinese have used the extract from the *gingko biloba*, a unique species of tree native to China, which supposedly gave the consumer an enhanced state of alertness and the ability to work efficiently for long stretches of time.

So nootropics have been around for a long period of time. Right now, everyone's eyes are on the comparatively new drug, Modafinil.

What is it?

Banned by the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA), a body which oversees anti-doping policies in all sports worldwide, but approved by the Food and Drug Administration, Modafinil is a drug that is intended for narcolepsy (a condition marked by excessive daytime sleepiness and bouts of uncontrollable sleep 'episodes' during the day) but is being used off-label as a nootropic. Considering an ideal scenario, if you are someone who feels unmotivated, is not able to concentrate and understand things, then this drug will solve that by enhancing your cognitive senses and helping you connect things which seemed